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CEOs' self-disclosure on Instagram and consumer-brand relationships: the moderating effect of relationship norms

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ABSTRACT

This study examined the effects of chief executive officers' (CEOs) self-disclosure on consumer–brand relationships and the moderating role of brand relationship norms. To test the proposed hypotheses, a 2×2 factorial design was implemented with self-disclosure (high vs. low) and relationship norms (exchange v. communal) as the between-subjects factors. The results showed the interplay between the level of CEOs' self-disclosure on Instagram and the type of relationship norms between consumers and brands and their effects on consumers' attitudinal and behavioral responses. For participants primed with the communal norm, high CEO self-disclosure induced more positive attitudes toward the CEO and the brand as well as higher consumer intentions for self-disclosure, than the low CEO self-disclosure; these results were reversed for participants in the exchange norm condition. This study advances the theoretical understanding of brands' social media engagement using CEOs and provides practical implications.

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Introduction

With its exponentially growing reach, social media has become a key marketing communication platform for companies. According to Brandwatch (2019), 91% of retail brands currently use two or more social networking sites (SNS) such as Facebook, Twitter, and Instagram. By using SNSs as a marketing communication tool, brands can not only generate and disseminate creative content through their information feeds, but also invite consumers to 'get to know' their brands and build relationships in a way that traditional forms of marketing cannot achieve. In addition to leveraging relationships with consumers on SNS platforms at the brand or corporate level, a growing number of chief executive officers (CEOs) are engaging directly with consumers and various stakeholders (Conner 2018). For example, John Legere, the CEO of T-Mobile US, is well known for his frequent use of Instagram, where he shares pictures of his daily life which the public can 'like' or 'comment' on. This new form of engagement

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between CEOs and consumers may offer opportunities to demythologize their typical, inaccessible image and allow them to appear closer to consumers, potentially enhancing consumer–brand relationships.

CEOs' social media presence involves the social process of self-disclosure. Kaplan and Haenlein (2010) suggested two key elements to the social dimension of SNSs: social presence/media richness and self-presentation/self-disclosure. The former is a media-related component that indicates the degree of salience of interpersonal relationships in a medium influenced by its vividness and interactivity (Fortin and Dholakia 2005). The latter dimension refers to the fact that social media enables people to present their identities by revealing themselves (Kaplan and Haenlein 2010). By displaying an image that is positive or consistent with themselves, people attempt to control others' impressions about them (Goffman 1978). From this perspective, CEOs using their own accounts on social media platforms to spontaneously share their daily lives with the public is considered 'self-disclosing behavior.'

Traditional interpersonal relationships research has suggested that self-disclosure positively affects interpersonal relationships (Altman and Taylor 1973; Derlega and Chaikin 1977). In recent years, several studies have focused on the effects of self-disclosure on social media (Park, Jin, and Jin 2011; Kashian et al. 2017; Kim and Song 2016; Lin and Utz 2017; Utz 2015). They suggest that self-disclosures on social media by public figures, such as celebrities and politicians, may have positive relational outcomes (Kim and Song 2016; Jackson and Lilleker 2011). However, despite increasing research on the effects of self-disclosure on social media, little is known about how CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors affect their relationship with consumers.

The consequences of CEOs' self-disclosing communication on social media need to be understood in relation to consumer–brand relationships. It has been suggested that self-disclosing behaviors will generate positive responses from others only when these behaviors are perceived as appropriate within the relationship (Collins and Miller 1994). For example, divulging personal information in the early stages of a relationship may be considered 'too much too soon', such that the person sharing the information is prone to becoming less likeable (Altman and Taylor 1973). The appropriateness of self-disclosure is determined by situational variables such as relationship norms, which govern the behaviors appropriate in specific relationships (Derlega and Grzelak 1979). Considering that the evaluation of one's self-disclosure is affected by a recipient's perception of their relationship with the discloser, this study investigated whether consumers responses to CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors on SNS platforms differ based on their norms regarding consumer–brand relationships. This experimental study included a fictitious brand and CEO, through which the researchers empirically examined the interplay between the level of the CEO's self-disclosure on SNS platforms and the brand relationship norms consequently activated in consumers' minds.

Theoretical background

Anthropomorphism and consumer–Brand relationships on social media

The consumer–brand relationship paradigm suggests that an element of a human relationship exists between commercial brands and consumers (Fournier 1998). Fournier (1998) suggests that consumers not only obtain utilitarian benefits, but also seek the

symbolic meaning associated with brands. Moreover, some consumers build relationships with brands and generate emotions usually experienced with close friends or family (Fournier 1998). In accordance with this paradigm shift, researchers have applied interpersonal relationship theories to consumer–brand relationships (Stern 1997; Sung and Choi 2010). The relationship paradigm is based on the underlying assumption that brands can be humanized in consumers' minds to the extent that they can serve as a relationship partner (Sung and Choi 2010).

People tend to imbue nonhuman agents with human-like characteristics (Epley, Waytz, and Cacioppo 2007). This is related to brand personification, defined as 'imbuing trademarked or otherwise proprietary-named products and services with a human form and/or human attributes, including a generally distinctive physical appearance and personality' (Cohen 2014, 3). Advertisers and marketers often utilize this phenomenon in various ways using a spokesperson or brand character (Fournier and Alvarez 2012). Brands can induce greater product likability, enhanced positive emotions, and more favorable brand personality attributions among consumers using anthropomorphism as a marketing communication technique (Delbaere, McQuarrie, and Phillips 2011). A set of brand personality traits developed through brand anthropomorphism strategies can make brand images distinctive, memorable, and likeable (Aggarwal and McGill 2012).

Brands utilizing social media accelerate consumers' tendency to anthropomorphize brand images and build relationships (Wen and Song 2017). Moreover, social media provides a good opportunity for increasing consumer engagement with a brand's online communication, thus strengthening consumer–brand relationships (Dholakia and Durham 2010; Tsimonis and Dimitriadis 2014). Social media enables brand managers to interact with consumers in ways that resemble daily interpersonal relationships, which makes them more personalized and familiar to consumers (Fournier 1998; Labrecque 2014). In addition, regular and direct communication on social media might lead consumers to engage in conversation with the brand, thereby increasing brand sales and expanding the customer base (Tsimonis and Dimitriadis 2014). A brand's social media presence with human representatives results in more favorable consumer responses than their presence without human representatives (Wen and Song 2017; Barcelos, Dantas, and Sénécal 2018). In fact, top global brands use human representatives on Twitter to imbue their brands with a human personality (Kwon and Sung 2011).

Accordingly, companies tend to employ a strategy in which they utilize their CEOs to humanize brand images and enhance relationships with consumers. The impact of CEOs on advertising effectiveness and branding has been acknowledged by several studies (Kerin and Barry 1981; Reidenbach and Pitts 1986; Kitchen and Laurence 2003; Argenti and Druckenmiller 2004). CEOs and famous company founders as spokespersons in advertisements can evoke positive feelings toward the brand and increase its credibility (Fleck, Michel, and Zeitoun 2014). Nevertheless, there is a dearth of research on the role of CEOs in brands' social media communication and the impact of their social media engagement. Thus, the present study sheds light on CEO–consumer communication on social media and its impact on consumer attitudes toward brands. In particular, this study focuses on the effects of self-disclosure, since posting on social media includes many forms of self-disclosure (Lin, Zhang, et al. 2016).

Self-disclosure

Self-disclosure refers to 'willful' disclosure of personally relevant information, thoughts, and feelings (Altman and Taylor 1973; Park, Jin, and Jin 2011; Derlega and Chaikin 1977). The development of self-disclosure is based on the dimensions of depth (quality) and breadth (quantity) (Collins and Miller 1994). Depth, which is related to the intimacy level conveyed through the disclosure, has been more widely used to manipulate or measure the level of self-disclosure than breadth, which is associated with the amount of information disclosed (Altman and Taylor 1973). Previous research has shown that self-disclosure generates positive relational outcomes (Altman and Taylor 1973; Derlega and Chaikin 1977). First, self-disclosure increases the feeling of intimacy. Perlman and Fehr (1987) suggest that intimacy, a feeling of closeness to one's relationship partner, is enhanced when relationship partners disclose personal details to each other. Altman and Taylor (1973) social penetration theory explains relationship development based on self-disclosure and intimacy. They suggest that an individual's personality consists of multiple layers, and as an individual moves from superficial to deeper levels of self-disclosure, revealing more of their personality, it increases the level of intimacy with their relationship partner, thereby enhancing the relationship itself (Altman and Taylor 1973).

Self-disclosure also leads people to have a positive attitude toward the person who disclosed personal details about themselves (Collins and Miller 1994; Altman and Taylor 1973). Collins and Miller (1994) explained that once a recipient perceives the discloser's self-disclosing behaviors as a sign of the discloser's approval of the recipient and their desire to develop the relationship, the recipient's attraction to the discloser increases, as explained by the reciprocity principle of attraction (Kenny 1994). Furthermore, self-disclosing behaviors may lead people to form positive beliefs about the discloser, since they view a person who reveals intimate information as friendly, trustworthy, and warm (Wheeless and Grotz 1976).

Social media offers novel platforms for users to broadcast their personal information and receive updates on other people's lives. Thus, communication on SNS platforms is deeply related to self-disclosure (Bazarova 2012; Kashian et al. 2017; Utz 2015). Self-disclosure on SNSs involves broadcasting status updates/posts that contain any kind of self-information (Lin, Levordashka, and Utz 2016). This self-information includes descriptive information, such as the incidents that transpire in one's daily life, as well as evaluative information, such as what one thinks or feels about an event (Lin and Utz 2017). SNSs require self-disclosure, and intimate self-disclosure is quite common on these platforms (Joinson et al. 2011; Ledbetter et al. 2011; Nguyen, Bin, and Campbell 2012).

Consistent with the literature on interpersonal relationships, recent studies have revealed a positive association between self-disclosure and relationships on SNSs (Mazer, Murphy, and Simonds 2009; Baruh and Cemalcılar 2015). Specifically, perceived intimacy on Twitter is enhanced merely by following others and viewing their status updates (Lin, Levordashka, and Utz 2016). Drawing on the concept of mediated voyeurism and uncertainty reduction theory, Baruh and Cemalcılar (2015) revealed that uploading posts on SNSs increased intimacy, which positively affected the time that viewers spent on the uploader's pages and their level of confidence in making

attributions about the page owner. This in turn reduced the level of uncertainty regarding the relationship and increased trust. Self-disclosure on SNSs also increases parasocial interaction experiences with celebrities by enhancing users' feeling of social presence (Kim and Song 2016). Political communication studies have found that self-disclosure on social media has positive effects on impression management (Jackson and Lilleker 2011). Meanwhile, previous research also suggests that self-disclosure on SNSs is distinct from that in offline relationships, as SNS posts are often directed at the public or at multiple recipients, including people whom one barely knows (Bazarova 2012). The public sharing circumstances of social media may defy the assumption of traditional self-disclosure studies that disclosures are generally restricted to close, trusted associates (Derlega and Chaikin 1977). Thus, studies in the context of SNS have delved into the question of what creates differences in the outcomes of self-disclosing behaviors.

CEOs' self-disclosure on SNSs

Self-disclosure occurs when CEOs communicate with the public through social media. The importance of CEOs in brand communication has been widely acknowledged. Since CEOs are public figures who communicate their brand visions (Men and Tsai 2016) and are closely related to brand success (Ranft et al. 2006), CEOs' behaviors greatly affect how people perceive brands. CEOs are among the many brand endorsers/spokespersons, such as celebrities and employees, who can add a humanized voice to brand communication and whose images affect consumer perceptions toward brands (Fleck, Michel, and Zeitoun 2014; Men and Tsai 2016). However, CEOs are distinguished from other types of endorsers/spokespersons in that they are perceived as a real person, like employees, but possess powerful and exceptional social influence, like celebrities (Fleck, Michel, and Zeitoun 2014). Because of the benefits offered by their intermediary positions, an increasing number of CEOs are making their presence felt on social media and being depicted as social CEOs. Previous studies have shown that CEO social media presence has a positive impact on brand equity, consumer–brand relationships, relational outcomes such as trust and satisfaction toward the organization, and even stock returns (Tsai and Men 2017; Gao 2019). Such outcomes can be explained by positive impressions toward CEOs, which are built on their authentic and approachable communication on social media (Men and Tsai 2016).

Given that SNSs require self-disclosure by default and that SNS posts reveal the uploader's information (Joinson et al. 2011; Ledbetter et al. 2011; Nguyen, Bin, and Campbell 2012), it is essential to consider the effects of CEOs' self-disclosure on consumer responses to CEOs' social media presence. Based on the literature (Park, Jin, and Jin 2011; Lin and Utz 2017; Kashian et al. 2017), a CEO's self-disclosure on SNSs can be defined as a CEO's 'willful' disclosure of personally relevant information through SNS posts. This may include any stories, experiences, or thoughts that CEOs encounter in their daily lives. In fact, recently, CEOs have blurred the boundaries between public and private information: information that used to be considered private in the past – such as aspects of personal lives (i.e. personal feelings like gratitude and sympathy) as well as professional lives (i.e. ongoing issues on the business front,

such as discussions on company relocation) – has now become public information as CEOs upload them on SNSs (Jameson 2014). Despite a few studies on the impact of CEOs' communication strategies on social media (Alghawi, Yan, and Wei 2014; Tsai and Men 2017), there is a dearth of research on the effects of CEOs' self-disclosure on SNSs in the context of consumer–brand relationships. CEOs' self-disclosure on SNS needs to be understood in the context of the characteristics of the relationships. Self-disclosure is not simply an individual behavior but a social action (Antaki, Barnes, and Leudar 2005; Utz 2015), and thus, its effects depend not only on the content of the information but also on the context (Bazarova 2012). Previous research suggests that the characteristics of the consumer-brand relationships affect consumers' motivational orientations and responses to brand communications (Simon 2017; Aggarwal 2004). Considering that CEOs are deeply associated with the firms (s)he direct and their activities are understood in relation to the firms (Jin and Yeo 2011; Reidenbach and Pitts 1986; Fleck, Michel, and Zeitoun 2014), examination of CEOs' self-disclosure on SNSs must take into account the brand relationship effects.

Relationship norms

Prior research in social psychology has highlighted the crucial role of norms in interpersonal relationships, as they tend to be used to judge the appropriateness of others' behaviors (Derlega and Grzelak 1979). Relationship norms include expectations regarding our own behaviors as well as that of others (Aggarwal 2004). Based on distinct norms, Clark and Mils (1993) identified two types of relationships: a close or communal relationship and a casual or exchange relationship. This distinction is based on the norms that govern the giving and receiving of benefits between relationship partners. In an exchange relationship such as that between business partners or even strangers, benefits are generally provided with the expectation of receiving a comparable benefit in return, leading people to be less likely to care for others at a personal level (Clark and Mils 1993). In contrast, in a communal relationship, such as among friends or family members, people tend to provide benefits without expectation of repayment and take care of their relationship partners, demonstrating an authentic concern for one another (Clark and Mils 1993; Aggarwal and Law 2005).

The relationship norms framework has also been applied to the context of consumer–brand relationships based on the assumption that consumers form relationships with brands in ways similar to interpersonal relationships (Fournier 1998; Stern 1997; Sung and Choi 2010). Prior research suggests that consumer attitudinal and behavioral responses to brand messages are influenced by brand relationship norms activated in the current phase of the brand relationship (Simon 2017; Fournier and Alvarez 2012; Aggarwal 2004; Wan, Hui, and Wyer 2011). Aggarwal and Law (2005) demonstrated that brand information is processed at different levels of abstraction depending on the activated relationship norms. Brand relationship norms have also been found to affect consumer affective responses (Wan, Hui, and Wyer 2011).

Aggarwal (2004) proposed a conceptual model to show how relationship norms affect consumers' brand evaluations. According to this model, if a brand's actions confirm the relationship norms consumers currently maintain, then the brand is likely to

be evaluated positively, whereas if they violate the consumers' relationship norms, the brand is likely to be evaluated negatively (Aggarwal 2004). For example, when people think of a brand as an exchange relationship partner, they are likely to evaluate the brand positively when it provides products or services comparable to the monetary value they associate with the brand, and they rarely expect to share personal concerns or familiar interactions. However, when people consider a brand a communal relationship partner like a friend, they are more likely to anticipate that the brand will transcend monetary interests and address their personal needs.

Hypotheses and research question

Based on the conceptual model of relationship norms and consumer evaluations, this study proposes an interplay between the level of CEOs' self-disclosure on SNS platforms and the type of currently active brand relationship norms. We expect that consumers who are motivated by communal brand relationship norms are likely to evaluate CEOs and their brands positively when they are exposed to the CEOs' posts disclosing personal details. Self-disclosure enhances the feeling of intimacy and positive perceptions about the discloser while reducing relationship uncertainty when self-disclosure is perceived as appropriate (Altman and Taylor 1973; Derlega and Chaikin 1977). In communal relationships, self-disclosure is seen as more acceptable and fit relationship norms because people in communal relationships take care of each other and are willing to develop and maintain caring relationships (Clark, Mills, and Powell 1986; Derlega and Chaikin 1977). In communal relationships, expressions of emotions evoke favorable reactions because they are seen as appropriate, functional, and called for (Clark and Taraban 1991). Thus, the present study expects that those who are primed to consider the brand a communal relationship partner, such as a friend or a family member, are more likely to view CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors as acceptable and appropriate, thereby evaluating the CEOs and the associated brands favorably.

However, people motivated by exchange brand relationship norms may be less likely to evaluate CEOs' self-disclosure positively. This is because in exchange relationships, revealing one's personal details is not expected and, thus, does not comply with the social norms of the relationship. In such relationships, people are neither concerned about others' welfare nor responsive to others' needs; rather, they are concerned about giving and receiving comparable benefits (Clark and Mils 1993). Thus, in these relationships, such as with a stranger or a business partner, people tend to suppress or avoid expressions of personal details. When an exchange brand relationship norm is primed for a CEO and a brand (Simon 2017; Aggarwal 2004), consumers are likely to expect the CEO's SNS posts about the brand's business and product/service, not intimate and personal details of the CEO. Thus, CEOs' disclosure of personal information would not match the norms in an exchange brand relationship, thereby making consumers perceive CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors as inappropriate and likely making them feel awkward. Thus, we hypothesize that when exchange brand relationship norms are activated, CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors on SNSs would lead to a less favorable attitude toward the CEO and brand than when communal relationship norms are activated.

Moreover, this study suggests that attitudes toward CEOs mediates the effects of CEOs' self-disclosure and brand relationship norms on consumer attitudes toward the brands. In marketing and public relations research, it is widely acknowledged that activities and images of CEOs are understood in relation to their brands (Jin and Yeo 2011). For example, the reputation of CEOs is intertwined with that of their companies (Kitchen and Laurence 2003). Argenti and Druckenmiller (2004) suggest that the images and perceived personalities of CEOs tend to blend with those of their brands. This is because a CEO is not just a spokesperson for the firm but also an important stakeholder who takes responsibility for and is deeply associated with the firm (s)he directs (Reidenbach and Pitts 1986; Fleck, Michel, and Zeitoun 2014). This association drives consumers to interpret CEOs' messages in relation to their perceptions about the brand (Zeitoun, Michel, and Fleck 2020). Perceptions of CEOs featured in advertising influence consumer attitudes toward brands (Fleck, Michel, and Zeitoun 2014; Newell and Shemwell 1995; Zeitoun, Michel, and Fleck 2020). Thus, we hypothesize that CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors on SNSs and consumers' activated brand relationship norms may affect consumers' evaluation of the CEO, which in turn affects consumers' evaluation of the brand. Given this background, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H1: In communal brand relationships, consumers will show more favorable attitudes toward a CEO with a high (vs. low) level of self-disclosure, whereas in exchange relationships, consumers will show more favorable attitudes toward a CEO with a low (vs. high) level of self-disclosure.

H2: In communal brand relationships, consumers will show more favorable attitudes toward a brand owned by a CEO with a high (vs. low) level of self-disclosure, whereas in exchange relationships, consumers will show more favorable attitudes toward a brand owned by a CEO with a low (vs. high) level of self-disclosure.

H3: Attitudes toward the CEO will mediate the interaction effect between self-disclosure and brand relationship norms on consumers' attitude toward the brand.

In addition to the effects on attitudinal responses, the present study addresses the effects on consumers' behavioral intention, such as the intention to disclose their personal information. In general, consumers are reluctant to disclose their personal information to brands since self-disclosure inherently contains high risk, which makes the discloser feels vulnerable (Moon 2000). Furthermore, consumers are concerned about their privacy and are skeptical about how marketers use their personal information (Lee, Im, and Taylor 2008). Despite such challenges, collecting consumer information is advantageous for companies as it helps them build positive relationships with consumers (Im et al. 2008; Lee, Im, and Taylor 2008). With regard to the consumer-CEO communication, consumers' self-disclosure might play an important role since the cycle of reciprocal and cumulative self-disclosing behaviors improves the overall relationship (Sprecher et al. 2013).

Among the many ways of promoting self-disclosure suggested in prior studies, one is the rule of reciprocity (Berg and Derlega 1987). Reciprocity, or responsiveness, occurs when one person's actions address the actions or content of the previous actions of another person (Davis and Perkowitz 1979; Berg 1987). In self-disclosure situations, reciprocity occurs when a disclosure recipient tends to match the intimacy of

the personal information he or she has received from a discloser (Berg 1987). In other words, if an individual shares personal details with a relationship partner, the partner tends to respond with a similar level of personal detail; this obligation to respond to the disclosure is due to a tendency to maintain equitable social exchange (Jourard and Jaffe 1970; Collins and Miller 1994).

The reciprocity in self-disclosure is determined by situational norms that affect the judgment of appropriateness of self-disclosure in that situation (Davis and Perkowitz 1979). Before engaging in self-disclosing behaviors, people judge the extent to which it is appropriate to reveal information in the given context or relationship (Lee, Im, and Taylor 2008). For example, in close or communal relationships, in which people have a norm of mutual responsiveness (Aggarwal 2004), they might be more responsive to a relationship partner's self-disclosure. However, in exchange relationships such as between business partners, where a high level of self-disclosure might be considered inappropriate, people might not be responsive to another's self-disclosure. In these situations, one's self-disclosure may embarrass the recipient or even elicit reticence, because the recipient might feel social pressure to reciprocate at an equally intimate level even when they feel it is inappropriate (Collins and Miller 1994). Given the reciprocity in self-disclosure and the important role of situational norms, this study examines how CEOs' self-disclosure and brand relationship norms interact to influence consumers' intentions to disclose personal information. Thus, we propose the following research question:

> RQ1: Is there, if any, an interaction effect of a CEO's self-disclosure and brand relationship norms on consumers' intentions to disclose their personal information to the CEO?

Methods

Study design and participants

This study examined the interplay between the level of CEOs' self-disclosure and type of brand relationship norms. The experiment followed a 2 (CEO self-disclosure: high vs. low) × 2 (brand relationship norms: communal vs. exchange) between-subjects design. In total, 125 university students ($N = 125$; $M_{age} = 22.84$, $SD_{age} = 2.54$; 72.8% female, 27.2% male) were recruited from a major university in South Korea, who participated in a 20-minute online experimental session. They received a gift voucher ($5.00) in return for their participation.

Stimuli and pretests

Instagram is a rapidly growing, image-based, SNS platform. The number of monthly active Instagram users has grown to 1 billion, and Instagram is now ahead of Facebook with a median engagement rate of 1.73% per post for brands (West 2019). Instagram enables users to share photos of their daily life with others, thereby publicly broadcasting their private daily life (Newman 2015). CEOs are increasingly using this SNS platform to share their daily lives with consumers and communicate directly with them (Conner 2018). Therefore, we used Instagram to test the proposed hypotheses.

Prior to stimuli development, we conceptualized an operational definition of CEOs' self-disclosure. The most common method of operationalizing self-disclosure is to manipulate or measure its level of intimacy (depth) such that intimate personal information is considered a higher level of disclosure than less intimate personal information (Collins and Miller 1994). Although some studies manipulate or measure the quantity of self-disclosure (e.g. the frequency of self-disclosure and the number of self-references in the message), the level of disclosure intimacy – the extent to which personal information (including personal experiences, attitudes, thoughts, and emotions) is revealed – has been widely measured or manipulated to examine the effects of self-disclosure in the context of computer-mediated communication and SNSs (Jiang, Bazarova, and Hancock 2013; Kashian et al. 2017). Previous research assessed the level of self-disclosure by estimating the level of disclosed information or facts about oneself, events in daily life, and personal feelings, opinions, and judgments (Rains, Brunner, and Oman 2016). Consistent with the conceptual and operational definition of self-disclosure in the literature, the present study operationalized CEOs' self-disclosure on SNSs as 'the extent to which the personal information of CEOs (including personal stories and experiences, thoughts and opinions, and emotions) is revealed in their SNS posts.'

Stimuli were developed based on the operational definition. The first step was to review the Instagram accounts of existing entrepreneurs and acquire real-life examples. Entrepreneurs with more than 5,000 followers were selected, and more than 40 posts were chosen from each one. Next, two sets of pretests were conducted to create the stimuli for the main study. The first pretest was conducted to evaluate the level of CEOs' self-disclosure in each post. Fifty university students ($n = 50$; 52% female, 48% male) were recruited from a major university in South Korea and compensated for their participation with coffee coupons. They were presented with the posts and asked to measure the self-disclosure level of each using four items. The items suggested by Mazer, Murphy, and Simonds (2009) (e.g. 'The instructor described on the Facebook website provided photographs' and 'The instructor described on the Facebook website revealed personal information about her personal life') were modified to fit the context of CEOs' self-disclosure situations as well as to measure their level of self-disclosure on SNSs based on the operational definition. The items included: 'The CEO reveals his personal stories', 'The CEO reveals information about his personal experiences or daily life experiences', 'The CEO reveals his thoughts or opinions', and 'The CEO reveals his feelings or emotions'. The items were internally consistent ($\alpha = 0.85$). The 40 posts were arranged based on the measured level of self-disclosure.

Next, the posts ranked in the top eight were selected and modified for the 'high self-disclosure' condition and those ranked in the bottom eight for the 'low self-disclosure' condition. Using the posts, two versions of a fictitious CEO's Instagram account were created. The CEO described on the Instagram account was an Asian male CEO in his 40 s, based on the disproportionately large percentage of male CEOs across diverse industries (White 2019). He was depicted as the CEO of a fictitious e-commerce company ("Amoy") to control any confounding effects of product category. The portrait of the fictitious CEO was only used in his profile photo, not in each post, to control potential effects of the visual presentation of the CEO in each

Instagram post. In this study, the fictitious CEO and brand name were created to minimize any potential confounding effects of pre-existing perceptions toward CEO and brand names. The two versions of the Instagram account differed only in the self-disclosure level of the posts. Other factors such as the CEO's profile, number of followers, and number of 'likes' were controlled.

Next, a second pretest was conducted to evaluate the manipulation validity of the fictitious CEO's self-disclosure in the two conditions. In total, 39 university students (n = 39; 76.9% female, 23.1% male) were recruited from major universities in South Korea and awarded extra credit for their participation. They were randomly assigned to one of the two CEO self-disclosure conditions. In the pretest, they were asked to view the CEO's Instagram account, including the manipulated posts, and assess the level of self-disclosure (using the same items used in the first pretest). The pretest results showed that participants in the high self-disclosure condition ($M_{High} = 5.58$, $SD_{High} = 0.64$) gave significantly higher self-disclosure scores to the CEO than those in the low self-disclosure condition ($M_{Low} = 4.67$, $SD_{Low} = 0.84$), t (37) = 3.77, $p < 0.01$. Thus, the results confirmed successful manipulation of the CEO's self-disclosure level. Appendices 1 and 2 provide examples of the CEO's Instagram posts.

Procedures

Upon arriving at the lab, study participants were randomly assigned to one of four conditions. In the first stage, they were instructed to read the scenario description related to one of the two types of brand relationship norms. The scenario description, modified from Aggarwal (2004), described a hypothetical relationship with a fictitious brand. Next, participants were shown the Instagram account of the brand's fictitious CEO. The Instagram account included eight Instagram posts. After viewing the Instagram account and posts, they were required to complete a post-experiment questionnaire, which included questions on the dependent variables such as attitude toward the CEO, attitude toward the brand, and their intentions to disclose personal information to the CEO.

Measures

Attitudes toward the CEO ($\alpha = .92$) and brand ($\alpha = .94$) were assessed using a three-item, seven-point Likert scale including 'favorable', 'positive', and 'like' from Muehling (1987). Participants' intentions to disclose their personal information to the CEO was measured using a four-item, seven-point Likert scale modified from Mazer, Murphy, and Simonds (2009). The items ($\alpha = .83$) included: 'I'm willing to reveal my personal stories to the CEO', 'I'm willing to reveal information about my personal experiences or daily life experiences', 'I'm willing to reveal my thoughts or opinions', and 'I'm willing to reveal my feelings or emotions'.

Results

To gauge the effectiveness of the manipulation of brand relationship norms, participants were asked to rate the extent to which they considered the brand to be on the

same level of intimacy as a close friend or family member (score of 1 on the Likert scale) or business partner (score of 7), as suggested by previous research (Aggarwal and Law 2005). The results showed that participants in the exchange norm condition rated the brand the way they evaluate a businessperson, whereas participants in the communal norm condition rated the brand the way they evaluate a friend or family member. Therefore, the relationship norms were successfully manipulated ($M_{Exchange}$ = 5.52 vs. $M_{Communal}$ = 3.33, $t = 10.77$, $p < .01$).

Hypotheses testing

A two-way multivariate analysis of variance (MANOVA) was used to determine the existence of any significant interaction effects of self-disclosure and relationship norms on attitude toward the CEO and brand. As expected, the MANOVA revealed no significant main effects of self-disclosure and relationship norms, except for the main effect of brand relationship norms on the consumers' intention to self-disclose (F [1,121] = 4.20, $p < .05$). The results revealed significant interaction effects for attitude toward the CEO (F [1,121] = 14.74, $p < .01$), attitude toward the brand (F [1,121] = 8.07, $p < .01$), and intention to self-disclose (F [1,121] = 15.47, $p < .01$) (see Table 1).

To examine the interaction effects, paired t-tests were conducted for each dependent variable. For participants with the communal norm, the CEO's high self-disclosure induced a more positive attitude toward him than low self-disclosure ($M_{High\ self\text{-}disclosure}$ vs. $M_{Low\ self\text{-}disclosure}$: 4.74 vs. 4.06; $t = 2.850$, $p < .01$). However, participants under the exchange norm condition revealed more favorable attitudes toward the CEO when exposed to the low self-disclosure scenario than the high self-disclosure scenario

Table 1. Descriptive statistics and MANOVA results.

IVs	DVs	Relationship norm	Self-disclosure	*M (SD)*	Mean square	*F*	Sig.
CEO Self-disclosure	CEO		High	4.36 (0.13)	.05	.04	.83
	Attitude		Low	4.40 (0.13)			
	Brand		High	4.47 (0.12)	.79	.84	.36
	Attitude		Low	4.63 (0.12)			
	Disclosure		High	2.58 (0.16)	.03	.02	.89
	intention		Low	2.61 (0.16)			
Relationship Norm	CEO	Exchange		4.36 (1.22)	.07	.06	.81
	Attitude	Communal		4.40 (0.99)			
	Brand	Exchange		4.51 (1.14)	.30	.32	.58
	Attitude	Communal		4.60 (0.82)			
	Disclosure	Exchange		2.37 (1.17)	6.69	4.20	.04
	intention	Communal		2.83 (1.48)			
CEO Self-disclosure × Relationship Norm	CEO	Exchange	High	3.97 (1.36)	16.57	14.74	.00
	Attitude		Low	4.74 (0.94)			
		Communal	High	4.74 (0.90)			
			Low	4.06 (0.98)			
	Brand	Exchange	High	4.18 (1.12)	7.56	8.06	.01
	Attitude		Low	4.83 (1.07)			
		Communal	High	4.77 (0.82)			
			Low	4.43 (0.80)			
	Self-disclosure	Exchange	High	1.91 (1.02)	24.65	15.47	.00
			Low	2.83 (1.15)			
	intention	Communal	High	3.26 (1.67)			
			Low	2.40 (1.14)			

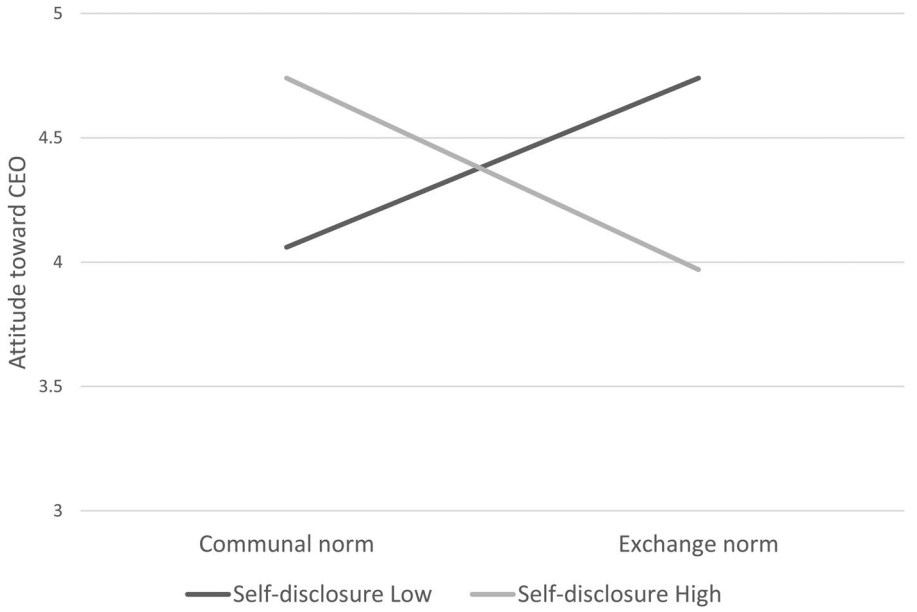


Figure 1. Interaction effects on attitude towards the CEO.

($M_{\text{High self-disclosure}}$ vs. $M_{\text{Low self-disclosure}}$: 3.97 vs. 4.74; $t = 2.66$, $p < .05$), supporting H1 (see Figure 1).

In terms of attitudes toward the brand, the results showed that in the communal norm condition, the high self-disclosure (vs. low self-disclosure) group evoked a more favorable attitude toward the brand, but the difference between the groups was not significant ($M_{\text{High self-disclosure}}$ vs. $M_{\text{Low self-disclosure}}$: 4.77 vs. 4.43; $t = 1.598$, $p = .11$). However, for exchange norm participants, low self-disclosure yielded a significantly more favorable attitude toward the brand than high self-disclosure ($M_{\text{High self-disclosure}}$ vs. $M_{\text{Low self-disclosure}}$: 4.18 vs. 4.83; $t = 2.396$, $p < .05$), partially supporting H2 (see Figure 2).

Furthermore, in terms of RQ1, the participants oriented to communal norms were significantly more willing to disclose their personal information to the CEO with a high level of self-disclosure than the one with a low level of self-disclosure ($M_{\text{High self-disclosure}}$ vs. $M_{\text{Low self-disclosure}}$: 3.26 vs. 2.40; $t = 2.33$, $p < .05$). However, for the participants oriented to the exchange norm, low self-disclosure evoked significantly higher willingness to engage in self-disclosure than the high self-disclosure scenario ($M_{\text{High self-disclosure}}$ vs. $M_{\text{Low self-disclosure}}$: 1.91 vs. 2.83; $t = 3.41$, $p < .01$).

Moderated mediating effects

To test H3, we conducted a moderated mediation analysis using Hayes' (2013) SPSS PROCESS macro (Model 8) to examine whether the relationship norm moderates both the direct effect of self-disclosure on attitude toward the brand and the indirect effect through attitude toward the CEO. Because self-disclosure and the relationship norm are categorical variables, we coded each condition with '0' and '1' (self-disclosure: low

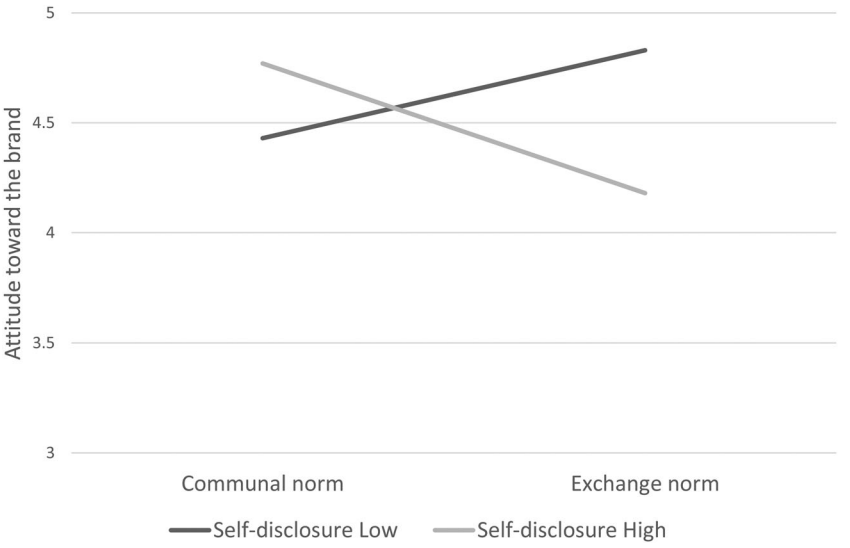


Figure 2. Interaction effects on attitude towards the brand.

condition= 0, high condition= 1; relationship norm: exchange norm condition= 0, communal norm condition= 1). We computed the moderation effects for 5,000 bootstrapped samples and computed a 95% confidence interval based on the effects at the 2.5th and 9.75th percentiles. As seen from the mediator variable model for predicting attitude toward the CEO, the main effects and interaction effect of CEO self-disclosure and brand relationship norms were significant (CEO self-disclosure: $b = -0.77$, $t = -2.92$, $p < .01$; relationship norm: $b = -0.68$, $t = -2.55$, $p < .05$; interaction effect: $b = 1.46$, $t = 3.84$, $p < .01$). In addition, according to the dependent variable model for predicting attitude toward the brand, only attitude toward the CEO was found to be significant ($b = 0.64$, $t = 10.80$, $p < .01$), as shown in Table 2.

Furthermore, the conditional direct effect analysis showed that the direct effects of CEO self-disclosure on attitude toward the brand were not significant in both relationship norm conditions (direct effect in exchange relationship norm condition $= -0.16$, 95% CIs [−0.51, 0.19]; direct effect in communal relationship norm condition $= -0.11$, 95% CIs [−0.47, 0.26]). However, the indirect effect analysis showed that the indirect effect of CEO self-disclosure on attitude toward the brand through attitude toward the CEO was significantly moderated by the relationship norm. For participants primed with the exchange relationship norm, a significant indirect effect was found in a negative direction (indirect effect $= -0.49$, 95% CIs [−0.90, −0.12]). In other words, in those for whom the exchange relationship norm was activated, low CEO self-disclosure evoked a more favorable attitude toward the brand through attitude toward the CEO than did high CEO self-disclosure. Conversely, for participants primed with the communal relationship norm, there was a significant indirect effect in a positive direction (indirect effect $= 0.44$, 95% CIs [0.14, 0.75]). As such, for those primed with the communal relationship norm, high CEO self-disclosure evoked a more favorable attitude toward the brand through attitude toward the CEO than did low CEO self-disclosure, supporting H3.

Table 2. Moderated mediation analysis results.

Mediator variable model for predicting attitude toward the CEO					
	B	SE	*t*	*p*	Boot 95% CI
CEO Self-disclosure	−0.77	0.26	−2.92	< 0.01	−1.29 to 0.25
Relationship Norm	−0.68	0.27	−2.55	< 0.05	−1.21 to 0.15
CEO Self-disclosure × Relationship Norm	1.46	0.38	3.84	< 0.01	0.71 to 2.21
$R^2 = .11$, F (3, 121) = 4.97, $p < .01$					
Dependent variable model for predicting attitude toward the brand					
	B	SE	*t*	*p*	Boot 95% CI
CEO Self-disclosure	−0.16	0.18	−0.89	0.37	−0.51 to 0.19
Relationship Norm	0.04	0.18	0.24	0.81	−0.31 to 0.40
CEO Self-disclosure × Relationship Norm	0.05	0.26	0.19	0.85	−0.47 to 0.57
Attitude toward the CEO	0.64	0.06	10.80	< 0.01	0.52 to 0.76
$R^2 = .53$, F (4, 120) = 33.75, $p < .01$					
Conditional direct effect analysis at values of the moderator					
Moderator: Relationship norm		*B*	Boot SE	Boot 95% CI	
Exchange		−0.16	0.18	−0.51 to 0.19	
Communal		−0.11	0.18	−0.47 to 0.26	
Conditional indirect effect analysis at values of the moderator					
Moderator: Relationship norm		*B*	Boot SE	Boot 95% CI	
Exchange		−0.49	0.20	−0.90 to 0.12	
Communal		0.44	0.15	0.14 to 0.75	

Discussion

The increasing number of CEOs engaging on SNSs is sparking growing interest regarding the effects of related CEO activities on consumers. The purpose of this study was to investigate the effects of CEOs' self-disclosure on SNSs on consumer evaluation of the CEO and the brand. By creating a realistic set of communication stimuli on Instagram, this study attempted to empirically examine the impact of CEO self-disclosure, identifying factors that could potentially affect consumer reactions to the CEO's behaviors.

The results empirically supported the prevailing assumption that CEOs' direct communication on social media affect consumer evaluation of the CEO and, ultimately, the brand. The results revealed that consumer evaluations of the CEO and the brand manifested differently depending on their self-disclosure behavior and consumers' conceptualization of the brand relationship. Specifically, consumers who considered the brand a communal relationship partner were likely to demonstrate a more favorable attitude toward the CEO and the brand as well as a higher willingness to provide their personal information when the CEO disclosed more personal details to the public rather than less. The results were reversed for consumers primed by the exchange relationship norm. Moreover, the results of a moderated mediation analysis revealed that the interaction between CEO self-disclosure and the relationship norm affects consumers' attitudes toward the brand through their attitude toward the CEO. This means that the relational outcomes stemming from the CEO's self-disclosure on SNS platforms spilled over into consumers' overall evaluation of the brand.

Theoretical and practical implications

Our findings provide several theoretical contributions. First, this study expands the theoretical knowledge on brand communication through social media to include the social media presence of CEOs. Previous studies have examined the effects of brand communication on social media (Voorveld 2019). Brand presence in SNSs has been known to have a positive impact on consumer–brand relationships by eliciting affective and cognitive elaborations, reducing brand uncertainty, facilitating consumer–-brand relationships online as well as offline, and thus enhancing consumer attitude towards the brand (Tuten and Solomon 2013; Jahn and Kunz 2014). Brands can remain present on SNSs through direct communication, such as having a brand account, embedding a brand persona, and publishing branded content (Yun, Pamuksuz, and Duff 2019). Another frequently used option for brands is to utilize spokespersons and engage in interactions with consumers, tapping into the unique nature of SNSs (Voorveld 2019). Previous research has investigated the effects of having diverse brand spokespersons on SNSs such as celebrities, influencers, and peer consumers (Mayrhofer et al. 2020; Schouten, Janssen, and Verspaget 2020). However, despite wide acknowledgement of the importance of CEOs as brand spokespersons (Reidenbach and Pitts 1986; Park and Berger 2004), research on the effects of CEOs' SNS presence on consumer responses was lacking. The present study filled this research gap by empirically demonstrating that CEOs' social media engagement – especially their way of engaging in social media communication – could affect consumer evaluations of the CEO as well as the brand.

In particular, using psychological theories related to self-disclosure, this study provided a theoretical framework regarding the outcomes of CEOs' social media engagement. SNSs enable public figures to reveal aspects of their personal lives and directly communicate with the public. Posts on SNSs disclosing the personal lives of public figures enhance parasocial relationships with the public, humanize their image, and ultimately help communicate more effectively and build relationships with the public (Kim and Song 2016; Kruikemeier 2014). Previous communication studies have also suggested that self-disclosure on SNSs may be counterproductive to the formation of positive impressions in some situations (Bazarova 2012; Baruh and Cemalcılar 2015). This is because self-disclosure on SNSs, compared to that in face-to-face communication, is often public, directed to a large number of viewers, and involves information that is more intimate than a viewer expects (Lin and Utz 2017; Baruh and Cemalcılar 2015). The unique properties of self-disclosure on SNSs distinguish its outcomes from those in traditional face-to-face communications (Lin and Utz 2017; Ledbetter et al. 2011; Nguyen, Bin, and Campbell 2012). Thus, the literature on self-disclosure on SNSs has identified factors that affect the outcomes of self-disclosure, such as the perceived appropriateness of self-disclosure and the norms used to judge appropriateness in different contexts (Lin and Utz 2017; Bazarova 2012; Nguyen, Bin, and Campbell 2012). The present study adds to this literature by empirically demonstrating that the effects of CEOs' self-disclosure are moderated by brand relationship norms. As interpersonal relationships can be of different types and stages, the types of consumer–brand relationships vary, and each relationship type follows a different trajectory (Fournier 1998). Different relationship norms shape different gratifications that consumers derive from

interactions with brands (Simon 2017). In line with the previous studies, the current study's findings suggest that the impact of CEOs' self-disclosure should be examined alongside consumer perceptions of their relationships with the associated brands. Consistent with previous research in interpersonal relationships suggesting that people's expectations and tolerances regarding the level of intimacy in self-disclosure depend on the characteristics of the relationship (Altman and Taylor 1973), we found that the level of the CEO's self-disclosure in this study was positively related to consumer attitudes when communal relationship norms, which resembled those with friends and family members, were activated; meanwhile, the level of the CEO's self-disclosure was negatively related to consumer attitudes when exchange relationship norms, similar to those with acquaintances and business partners, were activated. This supports assertions in previous studies (Batra, Ahuvia, and Bagozzi 2012; Sung and Choi 2010) that interpersonal relationship theories are helpful in understanding the relationships between consumers and a brand.

This study has important practical implications for companies and can provide helpful guidelines for CEO engagement on social media, particularly on SNSs. Although many marketers recommend CEOs to be engaged on social media because of its growing power, high-profile CEOs still lack social media presence (Nusca 2016). This is because CEOs' social media presence sometimes backfires on their reputations as well as their brand's image (McGregor 2018). In line with previous studies (Tsai and Men 2017; Gao 2019; Jameson 2014), our results suggest that CEOs' social media presence has an impact on consumer evaluations. Thus, CEOs should be aware that their activities on SNSs, for example, the posts that they upload to their personal accounts, affect relationships between consumers and the brands they own. CEOs' endeavor on SNSs to open themselves up and actively engage with consumers might help them leverage favorable consumer-brand relationships.

Furthermore, like many celebrities who have become popular influencers on social media (Schouten, Janssen, and Verspaget 2020), CEOs have a potential to become social media influencers by engaging with their followers and building up social networks. As social media influencers, CEOs could reach a broad range of potential consumers as well as existing loyal consumers of their brands. Engagement with followers on social media would lead CEOs to be perceived as authentic and approachable, thereby increasing trust and satisfaction with the brands (Men and Tsai 2016). Recent studies have also shown the benefits of influencer endorsement on enhancing brand evaluations (Schouten, Janssen, and Verspaget 2020; De Veirman and Hudders 2020). Thus, for CEOs who successfully manage their social media accounts and become influential on social media, social media would provide a great opportunity to amplify their brands and improve brand evaluations. Advertisers, marketers, and CEOs should be aware the potential benefits of CEOs' social media engagement.

The findings of this study also suggest that such impact is not unconditionally positive, rather that the impact of CEOs' social media activities may vary depending on the context and norms of the relationship between consumers and the brand. Thus, CEOs should be careful to what type of content they upload. We encourage those who consider social media a means to communicate with the public and enhance their image and evaluations to first understand consumers' norms or expectations and

accordingly choose the content they post. By understanding how their brands are defined and perceived by consumers, CEOs could develop communication strategies and tailor their content to enhance relationships with consumers on social media. CEOs should also consider working with communication professionals who are knowledgeable about social media communication tactics to become successful social CEOs and avoid possible risks associated with social media activities. Moreover, since this study imitated a real situation in which a consumer finds a CEO on Instagram and reviews his/her posts, the results can help marketers and CEOs gain realistic insights into how a CEO's engagement through an SNS can affect consumers' evaluations of the company.

Limitations and future research

Several limitations of this study should be acknowledged, which can provide useful directions for future studies. First, individual differences require exploration. For example, people's level of self-monitoring affects their responses to the self-disclosure of others (Shaffer, Smith, and Tomarelli 1982). Thus, individual difference variables such as self-monitoring must be examined. Second, although we measured the CEO's level of self-disclosure in each post, the topics or characteristics of the posts, such as whether it was geared toward information or entertainment, were not reviewed. Therefore, future studies should explore the effects of post types and characteristics.

Moreover, by using a fictitious brand and CEO that were completely new to participants, we controlled the potential confounding effects of brand and CEO characteristics. However, in reality, it is undeniable that the effects of a CEO's self-disclosure could interact with the public's pre-existing knowledge or images associated with the brand as well as the CEO. Thus, by utilizing CEOs who are already known to consumers, future research should investigate how knowledge about the CEOs affects the outcomes of CEOs' self-disclosing behaviors. Additionally, although the present study focused on the effects of CEOs' disclosure, self-disclosure may also occur through other types of spokespersons, such as animated brand characters. Thus, future research could investigate if our findings persist for other types of spokespersons. Finally, although we examined the impact of CEOs' self-disclosure on consumer attitude based on the literature suggesting the mediating roles of intimacy and disclosure appropriateness (Lin, Levordashka, and Utz 2016; Jiang, Bazarova, and Hancock 2011; Altman and Taylor 1973), we did not directly measure the mediating effects of these variables. Thus, future studies should measure intimacy or emotional support, which could further explain the relationship between CEOs' self-disclosure and consumer–-brand relationships.

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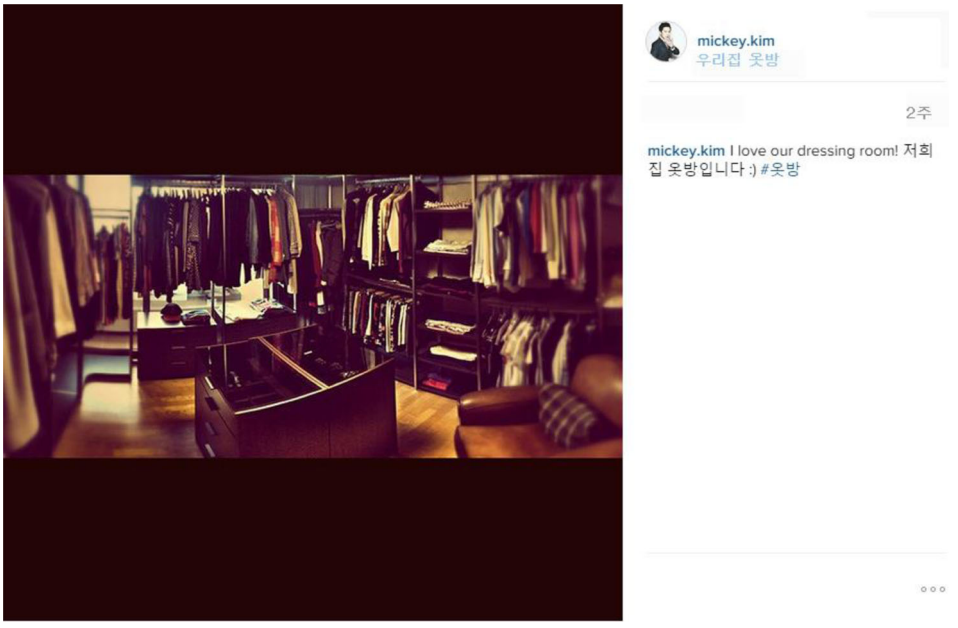
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Appendix 1. Examples of the CEO's posts in the high self-disclosure condition



A post about the CEO's closet with a location tag (The Korean caption in the post can be translated as, "This is my dressing room:) #dressingroom")

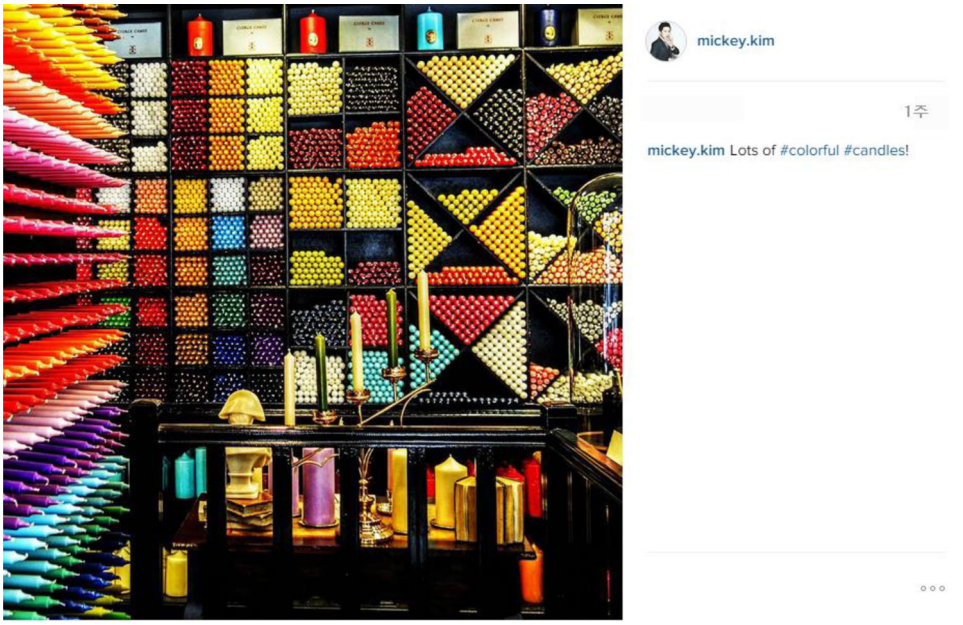


A post about the CEO's grandfather with a location tag (The Korean caption in the post can be translated as, "This is the picture of my grandpa when he was young. He looks so awesome in the picture.")

Appendix 2. Examples of the CEO's posts in the low self-disclosure condition



A post about city view and weather without a location tag, bottom (The Korean caption in the post can be translated as, "The sky looks awesome today. Autumn is coming.")



A post about a candle store without a location tag

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